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Modes of persuasion

Author(S): Rasmussen, Susan J.

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Illness and Property Conflict • The Case of the Stolen Alarm Clock

One is not supposed to express anger directly to anyone, but in particular, in respect toward affines and in joking with cross-cousins, potential marriage partners. So invoking spirits in music and verbal art empowers latent hostility and channels conflict where the status quo cannot so easily be challenged directly, due to close close residential, economic, and kinship relationships of the parties. Cousins and sisters share tasks in communal work obligations and also food and household tools. These need attending to. So again, there is more occurring than mere "ritual of rebellion." This is further illustrated in a conflict of a somewhat different nature. The role of speech in articulating theft of personal possessions, exposes sources and channels of power that turn on similar rules, but are different in other respects. The following case, a non-possession case involving an outsider, myself the researcher, is included because, in my view, it acts as a "foil" for characters and events in the cases above.

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The Case of the Stolen Alarm Clock

During an evening rest stop on travel to Agadez, my small battery-operated alarm clock was stolen from baggage left on the truck. Tuareg say theft under normal circumstances in rural society is rare, but occurs more frequently during travel, when an individual's character is believed to change, free from kinship and class restraints. The day after the theft, a marabout and friend of mine read verses in the Koran that Tuareg believe to be effective in compelling the thief to return the merchandise. These verses, when pronounced aloud, are believed to change the sentiment of the thief and cause him or her to want to return what was stolen. Later, other friends attempted to help me by

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pretending to be looking for a clock to buy for themselves, describing its features, and asking travelers if they had seen it, in the hope that the guilty party would inadvertently reveal himself by selling it. Finally, about two months after the theft, Bado, resident of a small village about seven miles from the village where I resided, reportedly displayed a clock to family and friends matching the description of the stolen one. Bado's sister resided in the same village as I, and local residents dispatched her to convince him to return it. Local residents exerted additional pressure on the suspect by gossip, insult, and ridicule; for example, they called him an *ekli*, (household slave), in this instance a pejorative term since he claimed noble origins. In the meantime friends and also my fictive "mother," with whom I boarded, brought compensatory gifts of tea, sugar, and goat cheese to me, underlining their great embarrassment that the theft had occurred, as I was their long-term guest. But there was never any intervention by outside jural authorities, secular courts, bush police, or Agadez police. Nor was there an exorcism ceremony. For I was an outsider. More importantly, although the event was upsetting to me because it cast doubt on whom I could trust and upsetting to my fictive family because it forced them to admit that theft did sometimes occur in their community, this problem did not involve "an illness of the heart and soul," the prerequisite, friends told me, for the staging of a possession ritual.

Finally, Bado returned the clock, but through a channel of intermediaries (from his relatives to my neighbor and family-host friends), rather than directly or through his sister.

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This conflict involved theft of an article of property by an individual unacquainted personally with the victim, except through distant knowledge of my long-term residence and friendship with mutual acquaintances. There were attempts to identify him through ritual and social processes (of Koranic divination and gossip and insult, respectively) and a final recovery of the property through intermediaries. ■42 I was throughout all this, particularly struck at, again, how powerful reserve, dignity, and their flipside, shame, operated as forces in shaping public opinion and mending ways. For their effectiveness, these were in turn, class and kinship-based. Here, conflict was experienced between two individuals who were, throughout the entire incident, strangers (that is, who lived in different villages and normally never interacted on a face-to-face basis). The verbal weapon alluded to class and descent origins, an insult to which Kel Ewey are particularly vulnerable because of their ambiguous and mixed origins. Slaves are stereotyped as thieves; nobles are stereotyped as honest, subject to self-control and dignity, and easily shamed. These latter qualities are a strength, a sign of noblesse oblige, but at the same time of course they compel the thief (of any origin) with noble pretensions to mend his ways. Like the polygynist husband who neglected Tina, and Tina herself who experienced feelings of conflict toward the matriline, and also like the young men who represented collectively a threat to Ramatou's household, perpetrators like Bado are subject to shaming by appeal to the prestige and advantages compliance offers in class and kin domains. In this last case my own status as outsider/researcher, yet at the same time long-term resident and friend, differed in specifics but nonetheless underlined the pervasive principles operating. There is ample room for manipulation of status, on bases of prestigious descent, class origins, material property base/prosperity, each of which may conflict with the other and each of which may in turn be evoked to fit the plaintiff's interests (and those of the plaintiff's allies). Herein resides the power to shame.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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